

ON TECHNIQUE

Expressive harmony

Perhaps the most striking aspect of Gesualdo's music is his extraordinary use of chromatic harmonies—that is, harmonies that are unrelated to the key in which the piece is written. Gesualdo used such unexpected and exotic chords for dramatic effect, to express the extremes of emotion and pain in his madrigals and sacred music. This idiosyncratic and often unsettling style distinguishes his compositions as among the most intensely personal music of the Italian late Renaissance period.



MADRIGAL SINGERS WITH LUTE AND SCORE,
VENETIAN, 16TH CENTURY

Carlo Gesualdo's highly expressive and personal style of composing, especially in his madrigals and sacred vocal music, reflected the mood of his turbulent life.